

The forest was breathing. Not in the way the wind shifts through branches or the way leaves sigh underfoot, but in a way that made Eliza's skin prickle. It was alive, pulsing with something unseen, something watching.

She had been walking for hours, the old map crumpled in her pocket serving as more of a comfort than a guide. It was barely legible, its edges worn soft by time and use. She had stopped relying on it a mile ago, realising that the landscape had shifted since the ink had dried. The trees loomed taller than she had anticipated, their thick, twisted roots threading together like fingers clasping a secret.

The sun was beginning to bow to the horizon, and she knew she should turn back. Every rational part of her screamed for retreat, but something held her there, a pull just beneath her ribs, urging her to take one more step. And then another. And another.

A rustle in the undergrowth. Eliza froze. The air thickened, heavy with anticipation. Her heart climbed into her throat, hammering against the fragile walls of silence. The sound came again. Not the dry scamper of a squirrel or the nervous flutter of a bird, but something deliberate. Something with weight.

Then she saw it.

At first, it was just a shadow - an absence of light between the trees. But as her eyes adjusted, the form sharpened. A creature unlike anything she had ever seen stood barely ten feet away, its golden eyes fixed on her with an unreadable intensity. It was large, wolf-like, but not quite. Its fur was deep, shifting in hues of obsidian and ink, so black it seemed to drink the last rays of sunlight.

Eliza's breath hitched. She had read stories, legends passed down in whispers, about creatures that walked the border of the real and the unreal. Beings that belonged to neither world, yet commanded both.

The beast took a step forward, its massive paws pressing soundlessly into the damp earth. It did not growl, did not snarl. It simply watched her, its gaze unwavering.

She could run. She should run. But her feet remained rooted to the ground as if bound by unseen strings.

The creature tilted its head slightly, curious. Its ears twitched, listening to something Eliza could not hear. A slow, deliberate exhale left its muzzle, curling into the cooling night air like smoke from an extinguished flame.

Then, impossibly, it spoke. Not in words, not in any language known to humankind, but in something deeper. A voice that rumbled through the marrow of her bones, a feeling more than a sound.

'Why have you come?'

Eliza gasped. It wasn't a question she had prepared to answer; it wasn't a question she had ever expected to be asked. Her mouth dried as her thoughts unravelled, like a thread slipping through her fingers.

What could she say? That she had been drawn here by something she didn't understand? That she had always felt there was more to the world than what could be explained by textbooks and logic? That she had come looking for something - anything - to prove that she wasn't just a girl with foolish dreams?

The creature waited.

'I- I don't know,' she admitted at last, her voice barely louder than the whispering trees.

The golden eyes held hers for a long moment. And then, slowly, the beast lowered itself onto its haunches, settling into the earth like a shadow returning home.

'Then listen.'

The word was both invitation and command. The wind stirred, carrying a whisper of something ancient, something vast. The trees seemed to lean in closer, their branches forming a cathedral of green and gold above her head. The ground beneath her feet hummed with life, a heartbeat she had never noticed before. Eliza closed her eyes, inhaling the scent of damp moss, of pine and earth. And for the first time in her life, she understood what it meant to belong to the world, rather than just exist within it.

When she opened her eyes, the creature was still there, watching.

The night was settling in now, draping the forest in its cool embrace. But Eliza knew, without doubt, that she had found what she had been searching for.

Or perhaps, it had found her. Whichever way that fate had fallen, their lives were now irrevocably intertwined. They turned and stepped together, back into the forest. Life was about to begin.